

A collection of playing cards. On the left, a 6 of Clubs is shown. Next to it is an 8 of Diamonds. To the right of that is a King of Spades. Further right is a Queen of Hearts. In the foreground, a fan of cards is displayed, starting with the Ace of Clubs and going through the 2 of Hearts. The cards are arranged in a way that suggests a game or a hand being dealt.

Count Sure Winners				
				Total

Decide How to Develop Winners			
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play

Count Fast and Slow Losers				
				Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Board: 3

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♠

Declarer: East

Board: 5

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 6 5

♥ 7 5

♦ K 10 9 4

♣ J 9 8

♠ J 4

♥ A 10 2

♦ A J 6 2

♣ A K 7 3



♠ 8 2

♥ K 9 8 6 3

♦ Q 7 3

♣ Q 10 4

♠ K Q 10 9 3

♥ Q J 4

♦ 8 5

♣ 6 5 2

With 9 points and a 5-card Major suit you should definitely transfer, so you bid 2♥. Partner replies 2♠.

With 9 points and a 5-card Major suit you should definitely transfer, so you bid 2♥. Partner replies 2♠.

Now you complete the sequence by bidding 2NT, trusting partner to put it in the right place. He has maximum points and a doubleton ♠ so he puts it in 3NT.

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 5

The contract would be 3NT played by South.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥6, West follows with the ♥5. What will you play from dummy? And what will you play from your hand.

It's not as bad as that Winner List looks; you can establish 4 ♠ winners very easily.

In fact, it looks so good you might wonder what could possibly go wrong. Here's something that can go wrong. The defenders take the **SECOND** ♠ trick with their ♠A. Can you get back to dummy for those other three winners?

Maybe you can and maybe you can't. It depends on what you played from your hand at the first trick. If you won that trick in your hand with the ♥A, then YES, you can get to dummy by leading twice toward the ♥Q J.

But if you won the first trick more cheaply with your ♥10, (or perhaps dummy's ♥J), and you still have that ♥A in your hand then East will prevent you from ever getting to dummy.

It is ingrained in Bridge players to win tricks with the smallest card possible. And while that is usually a good idea it can sometimes be a huge mistake.

Suppose you win the first trick with your ♥10. If you later play your ♥A then East's ♥K will stop you from getting to dummy. But if instead you play a small ♥ toward the ♥Q J East will grab his ♥K and your own ♥A will block your entry.

But if you take the first trick with a "spendthrift" ♥A then dummy's ♥Q J will become a guaranteed entry to the ♠s.

And notice - no matter which way you play it you still end up with exactly 2 ♥ tricks. So the play doesn't cost a trick, it just gains an entry.

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ K Q 9 6 5 3

♥ 6 2

♦ J 5

♣ K 10 4

♠ 10 8 4

♥ K 10 7 4

♦ 10 8 3

♣ Q 8 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A J 7 2

♥ A 8

♦ A K 6 4

♣ A J 3

♠ -

♥ Q J 9 5 3

♦ Q 9 7 2

♣ 9 7 6 5

West

North

East

South

3♥

Pass

4♠

Pass

6♠

All Pass

6♠ by East

Then play to dummy's ♠K. South shows out and you must temporarily stop drawing trumps.

For the elimination play to work you must strip ♦s from both hands. So play both the ♦ A K, then ruff a ♦ with the ♠Q. Pull trumps with your ♠ A J, then ruff the last ♦ in dummy.

The work is done. Just play a ♥. Whichever defender wins must either play a ♣ into your split tenaces, or play a red card and give you a ruff/sluff.

This is the complete Deal.

If you knew who held the ♣Q then you wouldn't have to learn Elimination plays.

These are the hands after the trumps have been pulled and ♦s eliminated from both West and East.

You now play the ♥, eliminating that suit from both hands. Whichever defender wins the trick must either play another ♥ and give you a ruff/sluff, or play a ♣ and give you a free finesse. Either way you will make the slam.

With a maximum 2NT opener, 4 of partner's ♠s and a doubleton you jump to 4♠, the Super-Accept.

Partner wastes no time bidding the slam.

East plays 6♠. South leads the ♥Q. South finds their best lead, exposing your ♥ loser. With a different lead you could have led toward dummy's ♦J, but not now.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

A very simple Plan would be for you to pull trumps and then guess who holds the ♣Q. Simple, but putting your slam on a 50% chance isn't very satisfying.

How about an elimination play instead? Win the ♥A.

Board 5

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 8 6 4
♥ Q 10 9
♦ K J 5
♣ Q 10 7 2

♠ J 2

♥ 6 5 4

♦ A 8 7 6 3

♣ 9 6 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 9 7 5 3

♥ K 8 7

♦ Q 10

♣ J 8 4

♠ A K Q

♥ A J 3 2

♦ 9 4 2

♣ A K 3

Partner has 20 or 21 points, balanced, and you have 6. You bid 3NT, hoping partner has ♦ K Q x.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣2 and East plays the ♣J.

Question 1: Do you hold up?

Winner List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		2NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Your best bet is going to be the ♦ suit, but dummy isn't exactly loaded with entries. How will you manage it?

The lead of the ♣2 tells you that West has only a 4-card suit, so there is no need to hold up. In fact if you did hold up East might play an unwelcome ♥ back.

When entries are really scarce the best approach is ducking. Win the ♣K and play a low ♦ from both hands. A defender will win this and probably continue with a ♣.

Stick to the plan. Win the ♣A and again play small ♦s from both hands, relaxing when both defenders follow suit to the second ♦.

They can now cash their 2 ♣s, and you had to give them 2 ♦s. But that's the only tricks they will get. Dummy's 3 ♦s are good and you still have a ♦ in your hand to get there.

When dummy has a long suit with no outside entries, always consider using a duck to make up for the lack of entries.

In this case it was a double-duck.